

Osteoarthritis Symptoms & When to See Your GP

Recognise osteoarthritis symptoms early. Learn the signs, risk factors and when to visit your GP. Trusted UK guidance for joint pain, stiffness and swelling.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Reviewed by **Clinical Advisory Panel** (HCPC-registered physiotherapy & rheumatology nursing input) · 2026-02-15 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

Osteoarthritis is the most common form of arthritis in the UK, affecting around **10 million people**. It occurs when the protective cartilage cushioning the ends of your bones gradually wears down, leading to pain, stiffness and reduced mobility.

Common Symptoms

Symptoms typically develop slowly and may include:

- Joint pain – Usually worse during or after activity, often described as a deep ache
 - Stiffness – Particularly after rest or first thing in the morning (usually lasting less than 30 minutes)
 - Swelling – Caused by inflammation or bony enlargement around the joint
 - Reduced range of motion – Difficulty bending or straightening the joint fully
 - Crepitus – A grating or crackling sensation when moving the joint
 - Tenderness – Pain when pressing on or near the joint
 - Bone spurs – Hard lumps that may form around the affected joint
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Joints Most Commonly Affected



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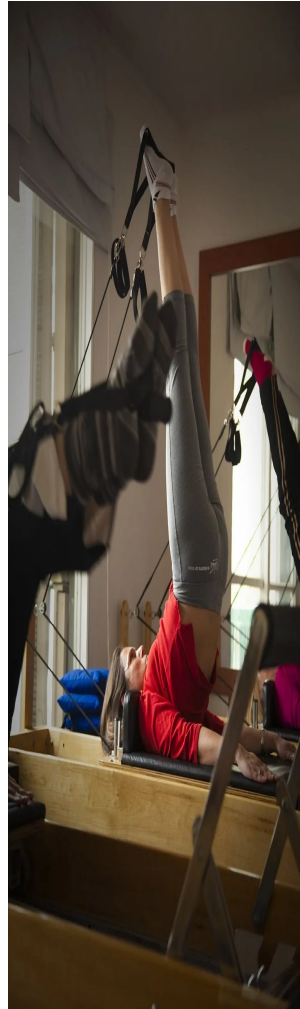
In the UK, the most commonly affected joints are the knees, hips, hands (particularly the base of the thumb), lower back and neck.

Risk Factors

- Age – Most common in people over 50
- Sex – Women are more commonly affected, especially after menopause
- Obesity – Excess weight puts additional stress on weight-bearing joints
- Previous injury – Sports injuries, work-related strain or accidents
- Family history – There is a genetic component to osteoarthritis

- Occupation – Jobs involving repetitive joint stress increase risk
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When to See Your GP



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The NHS recommends seeing your GP if:

- Joint pain or stiffness persists for more than a few weeks
- Pain is getting worse or affecting your daily activities
- You notice swelling, warmth or redness around a joint
- You experience joint pain along with fever or unexplained weight loss
- Over-the-counter painkillers are not helping

Your GP can diagnose osteoarthritis based on your symptoms and a physical examination. X-rays or blood tests may be used to rule out other conditions.

Managing Osteoarthritis

While there's no cure, symptoms can be managed effectively through a combination of exercise, weight management, physiotherapy and medication. Our virtual assistant can help you understand your options.

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about osteoarthritis symptoms & when to see your gp?

Short answer: Osteoarthritis is the most common form of arthritis, affecting millions. It occurs when cartilage cushioning bone ends wears down. Symptoms develop slowly and include joint pain, stiffness, swelling, and reduced movement. Common affected joints are the knees, hips, hands, lower back, and neck. See a GP if symptoms persist for weeks, worsen, or affect daily activities.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Versus Arthritis: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis UK · livingwitharthritis.org.uk